

Behavioural

Interview Cracker question bank

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Behavioural Interviews

Technically strong candidates lose offers here more often than they expect, usually for one reason: they answer in generalities instead of telling a specific story.

The STAR structure

		Time
Situation	The context. Where, when, what was at stake.	~15%
Task	Your specific responsibility.	~15%
Action	What you did, and why you chose it.	~55%
Result	The outcome, quantified where possible, and what you learned.	~15%

Two rules that fix most weak answers:

- 1 **Say "I", not "we"**. The interviewer is assessing you, not your team. "We
- 2 **Spend the time in Action**. Candidates over-explain the setup and then

Preparing properly

Do not prepare an answer per question - there are too many. Prepare **five to seven stories** and map them onto question types. Most behavioural questions are one of these:

Theme	What they are checking
Conflict with a colleague	Can you disagree without damaging a relationship
A project that failed	Do you take ownership, and did you learn
Leadership / influence	Can you move things without authority
A difficult technical decision	How you reason under uncertainty and trade-offs
Handling pressure or ambiguity	Do you prioritise, or freeze
Feedback you received	Are you coachable
Something you are proud of	What you actually value

A good story is **specific, recent, yours, and has a measurable outcome**. Write each one out once, in full. You will not memorise it - but writing it makes the details available under pressure.

The questions that recur, and what a good answer looks like

"Tell me about yourself."

Not your life story. Three parts, about 90 seconds: where you are now and what you own, one or two accomplishments relevant to this role, and why this role is the next logical step. Finish with a clear handover rather than trailing off.

"Tell me about a time you disagreed with a colleague."

They are testing whether you can hold a position without making it personal. A strong answer shows you sought to understand the other view first, brought **data** rather than opinion, and - crucially - either changed your mind or committed fully to the decision that was made. "I was right and they eventually agreed" is a weaker answer than it feels.

Avoid: stories where the other person is simply incompetent. It reads as a red flag about you, not them.

"Tell me about a project that failed."

The trap is choosing something trivial, or something that was not your fault. Pick a real failure with genuine consequences, take clear ownership of your part, and spend most of the answer on what you changed afterwards - and ideally, on evidence that the change stuck.

Avoid: "my weakness is that I work too hard." It signals that you either lack self-awareness or are unwilling to be honest.

"Tell me about a difficult technical decision."

This is really a system-design question in narrative form. Name the options you considered, the constraints (deadline, team skills, existing systems, cost), why you chose as you did, and what you would do differently knowing what you know now. Acknowledging a trade-off you accepted is a strength, not an admission.

"Why do you want to work here?"

Do the research. Reference something specific - the product, a technical blog post, the problem domain - and connect it to what you want to do next. Generic praise is transparently generic.

"Do you have any questions for us?"

Always yes. This is assessed. Useful ones:

- What does success look like for this role in the first six months?
- How does the team decide what to work on?
- What is the on-call and code review culture like?
- What is the biggest technical challenge the team faces right now?
- Why is this role open?

Common mistakes

- **Rambling.** Aim for two to three minutes. Practise out loud and time
 - **Hypotheticals.** "I would usually..." is not a story. Give a specific instance.
 - **No result.** Every story needs an ending, with a number if one exists
 - **Blaming.** Even when someone else genuinely caused the problem, focus on your
 - **No preparation.** It shows immediately, and interviewers read it as not
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A note on honesty

Do not invent stories. Interviewers ask follow-up questions - "what would you do differently?", "how did the other person react?", "what was the number before?" - and fabricated stories collapse under two or three of them. A modest true story, told well and with real reflection, beats an impressive invented one every time.

If you genuinely lack experience with something, say so and describe the nearest thing you have done. "I have not led a team, but I did own the migration end-to-end and coordinated three people across two teams" is a good answer. A fabricated one is a failed reference check waiting to happen.